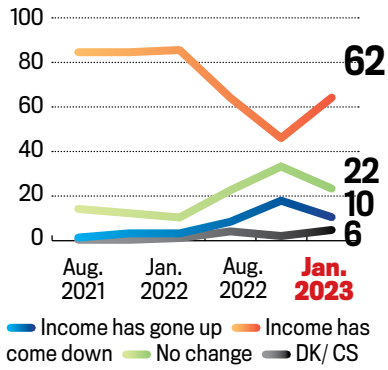
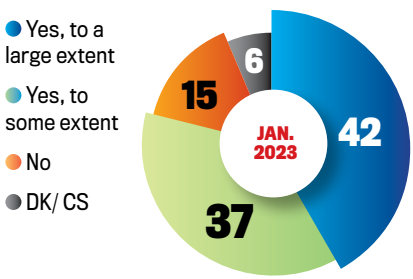
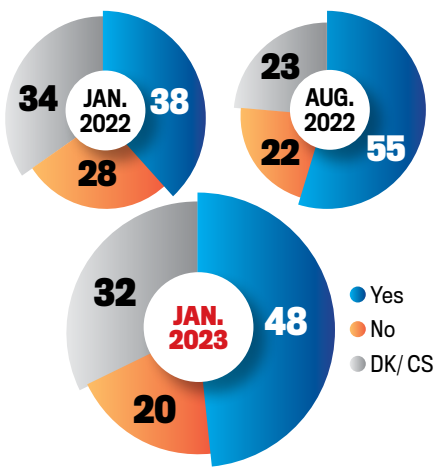
Q HOW HAS COVID-19 AFFECTED YOUR ECONOMIC STATUS?



Q HAS THE INDIAN ECONOMY RECOVERED COMPLETELY FROM THE COVID CRISIS?

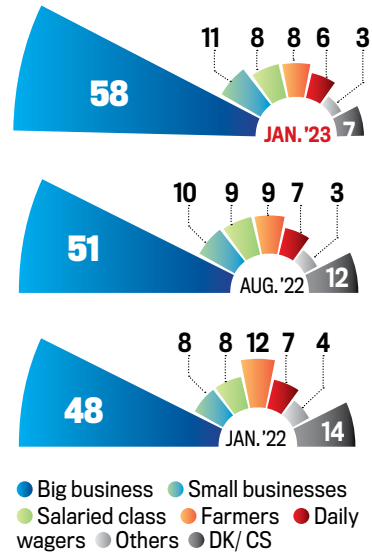


Q SHOULD THE GOVERNMENT BAN CRYPTOCURRENCY IN INDIA?



All figures in % and rounded off;
DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say

Q WHO HAS BENEFITED THE MOST FROM THE NDA GOVERNMENT'S ECONOMIC POLICIES?



ment, since Covid-19 continues to lurk. Nearly 62 per cent of the respondents report their income has fallen due to Covid-19, a huge rise from the 45.54 per cent who felt the same in August 2022. Those who reported a rise in income has come down to 9.5 per cent from the 18.5 per cent in the previous MOTN. Interestingly, 41.8 per cent feel the economy has completely recovered from the Covid-inflicted crisis.

No Money to Spend

The concern over joblessness is tied with the pessimism that household incomes will not improve. This, in turn, will constrain spending and, therefore, adversely impact investment. As many as 29.2 per cent of those polled feel their household income or salary will take a hit, marginally down from those who had the same response in the previous MOTN. As many as 37.4 per cent feel their income will stay steady, way higher than the 29.5 per cent who felt so in the previous MOTN. In a parallel query, 60 per cent say their current expenses have become difficult to manage, down from 63 per cent in August 2022. This is not difficult to imagine as the country has seen inflation breaching the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)-set upper limit of 6 per cent for several months now. It was only after a slew of interest rate hikes by the RBI that retail inflation fell to 5.88 per cent in November and 5.72 per cent in December. However, core inflation, which excludes the highly volatile food and fuel components, remains above 6 per cent. As many as 27.7 per cent say their expenses have risen but are still manageable. Only 10.7 per cent report a decline in current expenses.

The perception that this government's policies have mostly favoured big business persists. It has, in fact, grown to 57.7 per cent of the respondents in the latest poll, compared to 50.5 per cent in August 2022 and 47.7 per cent last January. Feeding this perception perhaps are the big-ticket announcements by industrialists like Gautam Adani and Mukesh Ambani who are betting heavily on the Modi government's thrust on infrastructure and green energy projects.

There is also a general sentiment against legalising cryptocurrency in India, with 48.4 per cent of the respondents calling for an outright ban on the digital tender, 6 percentage points lower than those who shared this opinion in August 2022. All eyes are on the impending cryptocurrency regulation bill, even as the Centre says any regulation or banning of cryptos can be effective only with significant international collaboration. Meanwhile, the RBI, having earlier aired its apprehensions on cryptos, has launched an e-Rupee on a pilot basis. ■